

as the original, leaving no room for complaint. It took 25 seconds for a black copy and 75 seconds for colour.

Next in line were the MFC-620CN and 5840CN from Brother at Rs 13,900 and Rs 14,590 respectively. These were the only two in this category with a sheet-feed mechanism for scanning—apart from the standard flatbed. Being up in this price range, one would have expected better quality from them, but they didn't seem any better than the 410CN with black printouts. The 5840CN is a pleasant change, with colour prints that are good for the most part. It also boasts of the highest paper capacity: 350 sheets. Ink saving takes its toll, bringing up visible specks in Normal mode. The copy mode, while not bad, could have been better on MFDs in this segment, especially with the Brother 5840CN, which boasts of a higher scanning resolution and bit depth than its... brothers.

At the top of the line sits the Canon MP500, which has, by far, the best print quality on offer here. It uses five colours rather than the standard four. In Normal text print, there were no smudges or gaps to be picked up even by a lens. Under Normal colour printing, speckles are visible. This can be gotten rid of by using the Best quality setting. Colour copying takes 123 seconds, and what you get is the best copy quality in this segment. Our only gripe is that there's

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Brother MFC-410CN

no network port, something missing on the MP450 as well.

Build Quality And Usability

The three Brother MFDs all have a fax dialpad and networking capability, which makes them better suited for an office environment. The positive feeling doesn't persist when we looked at their build quality: the plastic flaps were not as good as what one would expect of MFDs in such a high price range. The scanner cover does little to inspire confidence in the longevity of the device; ditto for the paper feed tray. Only the 5840CN exudes a rugged feel. The Canon MP450 and MP500 seem better built than the Brothers, but we would have liked them better if they had not been shaky. All the devices here have dedicated scan and copy buttons, making for ease of use. The Brother MFDs offer a fax button to ably support their fax keypads. Display, however, is a simple monochrome on the Brothers, while the Canons offer colour LCDs.

Our Conclusion

The Brothers have all the glory in the segment, with the MFC-5480CN taking the *Digit Best Buy Gold* despite being the second-costliest device here. Its good feature set and performance make up for the price. The MFC-410CN takes second place—the *Digit Best Buy Silver* crown, with a lower price tag, a good feature set, and value for money. ■

jayesh_limaye@thinkdigit.com
kailas_shastri@thinkdigit.com

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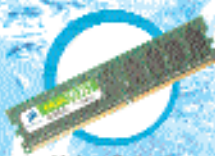
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